Marketing That Matters

Eight decisions that turn a good idea into a first go-to-market plan

Forty minutes on what marketing is.
Then a real business, real chocolate, and a plan built in the room.

By the end of tonight you will have a first plan you can test.
Not a list of marketing ideas.

Marketing is not advertising. Advertising is one tool. Marketing is choosing who, promising what, proving it, and making it easy to buy. Go-to-market is the plan that connects those choices to a paying customer.

STORY SLOT 1 · THE CAMPAIGN THAT WENT NOWHERE

Marketing changes a choice. GTM makes it happen.

One plan. Two jobs.
Build preference. Enable purchase.

Build what people remember and expect from you. And make one particular offer easy to understand, believe, and choose. One activity can do both. A good offer strengthens the brand. A known brand makes the offer easier to say yes to.

WEAK BRIEF

"Our coffee is excellent. Let's advertise to everyone and grow followers."

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

The customer change

Coffee-curious locals book and attend a paid discovery session, then leave able to name the flavors they like.

Booking and attendance are observable. Whether they got the benefit still needs checking.

Revenue is our result. It is not the customer's motivation.

One canvas. Same eight boxes in the lecture, the worked example, and tonight's workshop.

1
CUSTOMER CHANGE
What changes for the customer? What observable action shows it?
4 MIN

2
FIRST BUYER + MOMENT
Who chooses, pays and uses? When? Who is not first?
5 MIN

3
ALTERNATIVE + DIFFERENCE
What would they do instead? What difference matters? What should they remember us for?
6 MIN

4
OFFER + PRICE + PROOF
What can they buy, at what price? Why believe it?
5 MIN

5
REACH + PURCHASE
One first channel. Every step to a paid order. Who sells, who fulfills?
6 MIN

6
DELIVERY + RETURN + REFERRAL
What must delivery prove? What follow-up is welcome? Why return or recommend?
4 MIN

7
ECONOMICS + CAPACITY
Revenue minus serving cost minus winning cost. What can we actually deliver?
5 MIN

8
TEST + OWNER + DECISION
Evidence, risky assumption, test, owner, cap, deadline, threshold, fallback.
5 MIN

Mark every entry F observed fact A assumption Q open question. Unknowns are questions, not zeros.

Our operational synthesis of Seth Godin's Marketing Seminar. Not his official framework.

Start with someone. Not everyone.

A buyer. A buying moment. A deliberate "not first."

The buyer, the payer and the user may be different people. A useful first audience wants the outcome, can be reached, can pay, and can be served well. Smallest viable audience means focus with economics, not a tiny niche for its own sake.

30 SECONDS · THE ROOM

Improve "everyone who likes coffee."

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

First buyer + moment

A local planning a weekend outing for two. One person may choose and pay; both attend.

Not first: professional baristas, or anyone looking for the cheapest caffeine.

Q "Tell me about the last time you chose an activity like this. What did you do, pay, and worry about?"

Win against the alternative in their head.

Instead of [alternative], we help [buyer] get [difference].

Positioning is a reason to choose you over what they would actually do instead, including nothing. Identity explains which differences matter. "People like us do things like this" is a prompt to investigate belonging, not permission to invent a stereotype.

THINK MAC / PC

Two things at once: a story about identity, and a plain reason to switch. What is the equivalent of that connection in your business?

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

Alternative + difference

Alternative: a familiar café, or a different weekend activity.

Remembered for: discovery without intimidation.

Promise: "Discover what you like in coffee. No expertise required."

Your offer is bigger than your product.

Outcome + package + price + proof + a safe next step.

Turn the promise into something a person can evaluate and buy. What's included, what's not, the price, the terms, and evidence they can believe. Price funds the business and signals the positioning. Resolve a real hesitation. Don't manufacture fear.

WARBY PARKER, 2010 · HOME TRY-ON

"We make stylish glasses" became "try five frames at home before you commit." The offer did the marketing. Historical case, not a current recommendation.

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

Offer + price + proof

$80 per pair. 60 minutes, three guided tastings, a take-home preference card.

Proof: a truthful beginner-friendly agenda and a host introduction. Cancellation terms stated plainly.

A Package and price are teaching assumptions. Test willingness to pay and whether we can deliver it.

Show me how the first ten customers arrive.

Relevant discovery → credible next step → payment → delivery.

A channel is a route to the buyer, not a strategy. Pick the first one by concentration of the right buyers, trust in that context, and the cost of winning a sale. Separate the channel that introduces you from the mechanism that closes and the people who fulfill. Ten is a teaching number.

PAIRS · FIND THE MISSING STEP

"A newsletter features us, so we get customers."

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

Reach + purchase

Local newsletter placement → one beginner-tasting page → pick a session → pay $80 → confirmation → attend.

The roaster sells and fulfills. One channel, so the learning is readable.

A Newsletter access and audience response are hypotheses, not agreements.

STORY SLOT 2 · YOUR FIRST TEN CUSTOMERS

The first experience should earn the next step.

Deliver the promise. Earn permission. Give a reason to return or share.

Repeat revenue and referrals need a reason, and the customer decides what's remarkable. Permission is a welcome invitation to continue, not ownership of someone's attention. A one-time purchase can still be a good business.

THREE QUESTIONS

What must happen at delivery? What would make the next contact useful? Why would recommending us help the customer or their friend?

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

Delivery + return + referral

Run the session at the promised time and scope. Each pair leaves with a preference card and a story worth telling.

Separate opt-in to hear about a different future session. Don't assume they'll repeat, and don't count two attendees as two customers.

Growth has to survive the arithmetic.

$80 RECEIVED one unique paying buyer, one two-person booking	−	$35 TO SERVE materials, processing, a share of paid session labor	−	$20 TO WIN $200 all-in acquisition effort ÷ 10 new buyers	=	$25 LEFT before fixed overhead and profit
$80 RECEIVED	−	$35 TO SERVE	−	$50 TO WIN same $200, but only 4 buyers showed up	=	−$5 LEFT the first order loses money before overhead

CAPACITY

Two sessions, max eight pair bookings each: 16 bookings total. Confirm session timing, host hours and payment timing before promising growth.

SOURCE

All figures invented for teaching. Count selling time, samples and fees once, in one bucket. A bounded learning loss can be worth it; unverified repeat purchases can't be used to hide it.

Get. Keep. Grow.

Get

COST TO WIN ONE CUSTOMER · CAC

Everything you spent to acquire them, including your own time, divided by the number of new paying customers it produced.

Roaster: $200 ÷ 10 = $20. At 4 buyers, $50.

Keep

DO THEY COME BACK · RETENTION

A second purchase is the first evidence that the promise was kept. Until you've seen it, repeat revenue is an assumption.

Roaster: unknown. Not zero. A question.

Grow

WHAT ONE CUSTOMER IS WORTH OVER TIME · LTV

Margin per order × orders you can expect from one customer. Referrals make it larger. Every number in it is a guess until it's observed.

Roaster: $25 × ? Only the first order is real.

The rule of thumb investors quote: LTV at least 3× CAC, and CAC paid back inside 12 months. Treat it as a rule of thumb for venture-scale businesses, not a law. For a service business the honest version is: does the first order pay for winning it, and do you have evidence of a second?

WHERE THIS CAME FROM

Owed from S08. Get/Keep/Grow is Steve Blank's customer-development framing; LTV:CAC 3:1 and 12-month payback are the common venture heuristics in the program syllabus.

Launch a test. Not a belief.

What we know. What we bet. What would change our mind.

Godin's quality check on the same plan: Truth (evidence), Assertions (testable beliefs), Alternatives (fallback), People (owners), Money (resources). An elegant story is still an assumption until there's evidence. A small pilot earns another test, not a declaration of product-market fit.

THE ROOM

Look at the finished roaster canvas on the next slide. Where is the weakest assumption?

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE · A LOCAL ROASTER

The gate

Within 30 days: 10 unique new paid bookings. Acquisition effort capped at $200 including valued time. At least $25 left per delivered booking under verified costs. Delivery within capacity and promise.

Owner: the roaster.

If access fails, change the route. **If buyers arrive but don't buy,** look at offer, price or risk before adding reach.

The roaster's first plan. Eight connected choices, most of them assumptions.

1
CUSTOMER CHANGE

Coffee-curious locals book and attend a paid discovery session, then leave able to name flavors they enjoy. Booking is observable; the benefit needs checking.

2
FIRST BUYER + MOMENT

A local planning a weekend outing for two. One may pay; both attend. Not first: baristas, cheapest-coffee seekers. Ask about their last outing.

3
ALTERNATIVE + DIFFERENCE

A familiar café or another weekend activity. Remembered for discovery without intimidation. "Discover what you like in coffee. No expertise required."

4
OFFER + PRICE + PROOF

$80 per pair, 60 minutes, three guided tastings, a preference card. Truthful agenda and host intro as proof. Terms stated. Test package and price.

5
REACH + PURCHASE

Newsletter placement → beginner page → choose session → pay → confirmation → attend. Roaster sells and fulfills. Partner access unproven.

6
DELIVERY + RETURN + REFERRAL

Deliver the promised session and a useful card. Separate opt-in for a different future event. Easy to share. No assumed repeats or referrals.

7
ECONOMICS + CAPACITY

At 10 bookings: $80 − $35 − ($200 ÷ 10) = $25 before overhead. Two sessions, max 8 pairs each. Recheck labor and capacity.

8
TEST + OWNER + DECISION

30 days, 10 unique paid bookings, $200 cap incl. time, ≥ $25 left per booking, delivery within promise. Owner: roaster. Access fails → new route; conversion fails → offer/risk.

A connected hypothesis. Not a proven business, and not the answer to tonight's workshop.

Éclat Chocolate

West Chester, Pennsylvania · Chris Curtin, chocolatier

Chris will brief us on the business. Then we make the same eight decisions, together, for one audience and one buying occasion. The samples on the table are research material. Taste them like a first buyer would.

This is not a finding that Éclat's marketing is weak. It is a first plan and a test, built the way you'd build one for your own business.

A 30-day learning test. One audience. One occasion. Existing capabilities only.

F Observed

- Corporate gifting, custom branding, personalized messages and shipping options are on the public site
- Existing capabilities, not discoveries for us to claim
- Inventory, lead times and operating promises still need Chris to confirm

Q Unknown

- Segment demand and repeat buying
- Margins and conversion
- Recipient restrictions and gift policies
- Fulfillment capacity and management priorities

A Exercise constraints

- **$1,000** cash test budget
- **20** staff hours, valued in the economics
- **30** days
- One existing product or service
- One initial channel

Pick one audience

PERSONAL GIFT-GIVERS

CLIENT-RELATIONSHIP GIFT BUYERS

CULINARY EXPLORERS

None of these is pre-labeled correct. Costs and capacity get checked with Éclat before anything real launches. A missing fact becomes the first research task.

WORKSHOP CLOCK · 40 MIN

Build the plan in the same order we learned it.

CLOCK	BOXES	REQUIRED OUTPUT
0–5	**Brief, facts, unknowns, constraints. Taste.**	F / A / Q markings. One candidate audience.
5–13	**1 · 2 · 3**	One buyer and occasion. The change. The alternative. What Éclat should be remembered for.
13–21	**4 · 5**	A buyable offer, price, proof, and a purchase route that fits the promise.
21–29	**6 · 7**	Delivery standard, welcome follow-up, economics and capacity questions.
29–35	**8**	Owner, test, cash and time cap, deadline, threshold, fallback. Protect this stage.
35–40	**Consistency check**	Does this buyer want this promise? Does the offer prove it? Can the route reach them at the moment? Do costs, capacity and test match? Then: the next evidence task.

Score the plan on consistency, not on the best slogan. Do not count a tasting or an introduction as a sale.

Not Éclat's plan. A hypothesis to compare against yours.

1
CHANGE

An important thank-you feels personally chosen rather than routine. The buyer places an appropriate paid order.

2
BUYER + MOMENT

A professional-services client manager after an important engagement. Check approver, payer, recipient, gift policy. Not all businesses, all occasions.

3
ALTERNATIVE + DIFFERENCE

The existing gift supplier, a generic basket, another gesture. Remembered as "my source for thoughtfully chosen gifts." Thoughtful discovery with easy ordering.

4
OFFER + PROOF

Curated existing assortment, message, price, clear delivery terms that support Box 3. Confirm stock, lead time, price and proof before promising them.

5
REACH + PURCHASE

Professional-network introduction → gifting conversation → priced proposal → authorized paid order → fulfillment. Network access is an assumption.

6
DELIVERY + RETURN

Deliver within promised terms; verify satisfaction. Ask permission to be useful at the next appropriate occasion. No assumed repeat demand.

7
ECONOMICS + CAPACITY

Count contribution at the buyer-account or order level, not chocolates eaten. Include customization, delivery, selling time and exceptions. Get real costs.

8
TEST + DECISION

Verify access and economics first. Then paid pilot orders from eligible buyers with a pre-set threshold, owner, budget, deadline. Continue only to the next measured test.

The research prompts behind tonight's brief.

[SCOTT'S ÉCLAT RESEARCH PROMPTS · TO BE SUPPLIED]

Placeholder. Drop the prompts you used for the preliminary Éclat research here, one card per prompt, in the order you ran them. Suggested framing for each: what you asked, what came back that was useful, what came back that was wrong or unverifiable.

Full prompts posted to Discourse with the canvas. Run them on your own business before next session.

TAKE IT HOME

One decision. One assumption. Before you leave.

I

Name one decision you will make for your own business

One of the eight boxes. Say it out loud tonight. Not whether you enjoyed the session; what you'll do differently tomorrow.

2

Name one assumption you will test

With an owner, a cap, a deadline and a threshold. Box 8 for your business.

3

Fill the canvas

Two pages on Discourse: the roaster's completed example on one side, a blank on the other. Tag every entry F, A or Q. Bring it to the next session.

Slides, PDF, canvas and the research prompts go up on Discourse tonight.

A first GTM plan is not a confident story about why we will win.

It is a connected set of choices, and a disciplined way to find out where we are wrong.

STORY SLOT 3 · THE CLOSE